



Sachin Kalbag

Wake Up! The Future Is Local

It is a paradox of our times that, on the World Wide Web, we can find long-lost school friends whom you haven't met in 15 years, but cannot find the telephone number of the local 24-hour pharmacy. More often than not, we find an obscure spy document of World War II, but try finding details on your local municipal representative, and you will appreciate the trouble with information on the Internet. Quite unlike the 24-hour local telephone information services that are pretty prompt with information.

Google and Yahoo! launched local search sites some time back; MSN launched its local search engine in June. Good going. The bad news, not surprisingly, is that most of the local engines are America-centric. Yet, it is a precursor to the future—the tool that everybody wants; and everybody has been waiting for.

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We simply have to have a local equivalent of Google on the Web. For India, for our city, for our suburb, for our neighbourhood.

It is, therefore, another startling paradox that, in the age of information overload, we find local information is at a premium in our country. One of the easiest ways to access local information today is the local self-government body—the municipal corporations and its local offices. However, give or take a few, most municipal corporations and their officers are technophobes. You cannot expect them to create online databases that you and I can access when they are scared of the PC. Or so is the excuse that is meted out.

My theory is this: government officials are not scared of technology; they are scared of giving out information. Information is power; their only constituency, so to speak. This power gives rise to corruption. Hence, there is no logical (even if immoral) reason why they should give out information that can, theoretically, be “sold”.

One of the most interesting (and information-laden) aspects of local search is maps. Almost every US and European city is digitally mapped, and with aerial imagery now available on the Web (think

keyhole.com or TerraServer), it is almost tragic that India's satellite imaging prowess is not put to good use for that precious human connect with technology.

Truth be told, none of the three—MSN, Yahoo!, or Google—can add any value to our local knowledge if the information itself is not there in the first place. Ask the municipal corporation of Mumbai, the city where I live, about maps of Mumbai, and you will come up with a blank. Yet, the guys at Eicher Good Earth, a private firm, have published an entire book of Mumbai's maps, including valuable information on local shopping complexes, ATMs, apartments, hospitals, 24-hour pharmacies, and you understand why digitising a city's information requires intent and will, more than money. So, if Eicher can, why can't the municipality, especially since it is a treasurehouse of information?

All the three search giants throw up results indexed from local businesses and services. Nowhere have they invested their own resources to create information. The only money that has gone into these search services is for developing the programs that power them, and investing in the people who are doing it. It is a simple model. Try searching “Pizza Hut” in “Evanston” (Illinois, USA) on any of the three services, and you will not only get detailed addresses along with phone numbers, you also get maps, aerial imagery, and other options you could try out just in case. MSN's beta version of the local search also throws up Web results for good measure.

Not that maps and aerial imagery are anything new (MapQuest provided PDF versions of aerial imagery more than two years ago), but it was only in the last six months, post Google's acquisition of Keyhole.com, and the subsequent use of its aerial images by CNN, that the service came into prominence. Google, it would seem, did the right thing at the right time. So did MSN. So did Yahoo!.

Their success with local search is evidence enough that people care more about their neighbourhood than what it is happening in Poland or Sierra Leone. Or for that matter, whether US army personnel are hurling abuses at the inmates in Guantanamo Bay. If I want to know which restaurants in my suburb are open at three in the morning, someone better give me that information.

The call, therefore, goes around the Web: Wake up! The future is local. ☒

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